

GRAPHICS CARDS

Most of our readers who've been clamouring about DX 10 will know by now that Microsoft has duped us. The famed next generation graphics platform was nothing more than a technology changeover for them and a prepping platform for DX 11, which will be the next graphics standard. The few game developers who used the DX 10 standard in developing their games were rewarded with slightly better visuals and a whole lot more abuse from the gaming fraternity who more often than not experienced flagging frame rates from these new games. However, your DX 10 ready card is far from useless. At least MS got ATI and NVIDIA back to their drawing boards to come out with unified shaders, which has been the biggest shot in the arm for 3D gaming since *Doom*.

The biggest plus point for us has been the availability of cheaper, faster graphics cards. The previous generation high-end become the next generations' mid-range and the mid-range products become entry-level; all this in terms of pricing of course. The best example is NVIDIA's GeForce 9800 GTX. Cards based on this GPU were initially priced at around Rs 25,000; and this was touted as the replacement for the 8800 GTX.

Today, post the debut of the GTX 280 and a mere eight months later the 9800 GTX is priced at Rs 10,000. Its abilities haven't diminished, but better and faster cards have pushed it to the mid-range price bracket, which it rules, owing to its high-end origins.

High-End

REIGNING CHAMPION

Palit Radeon HD 4870 SONIC

Palit's Radeon HD 4870 has been an impressive performer since its inception and owing to superb pricing it's actually able to compete



BEST PERFORMER

XFX GX-280-ZDD9

This graphics card was based on an over-clocked version of NVIDIA's GeForce GTX 280 GPU. With 240 stream processors clocked at 670 MHz and a mighty 512-bit wide memory bus that feeds a massive 1 GB of GDDR3 memory clocked at 2430 MHz the XFX GX-280-ZDD9 is all about speed and raw power. With the exception of *Crysis* on DX 10 at maximum settings, which kills all graphics cards anyway, the XFX GX-280-ZDD9 can handle any game you throw at it. NVIDIA has managed to deliver a healthy 50 to 60 per cent performance increase with the GTX 280 series from their previous generation 8800 Ultras. The only possible downside we can think of is the price — this card commands a price tag of Rs 45,000.

with the GTX 260 at a lower price point. This card features a unique looking cooling solution with two large fans that really keep things cool; it never crossed 65 degrees on load — impressive. The card itself is lightweight and a superb performer, which makes it a sensible buy in the high-end category. Equipped with 800 stream processors and 512 MB of ultra fast GDDR5 memory the HD 4870 SONIC will easily run all your games at maximum detail levels and remain cool in the process.

CHALLENGER(S)

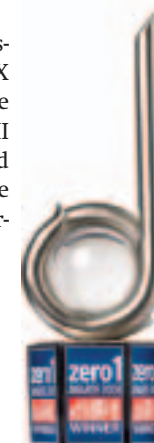
Palit Radeon HD 4870 SONIC 1 GB

What's better than a Palit HD 4870 SONIC with 512 MB of GDDR 5? The 1 GB version of course. Palit gave this card a much needed extra 512 MB of GDDR 5 memory. Priced at Rs 18,500, the Palit HD 4870 SONIC 1 GB is a gamers' dream

come true that manages to displace the much costlier GTX 280 in some benchmarks. The fact that this card has HDMI and DisplayPort connects and comes with a really effective cooling solution is the proverbial icing on the cake.

AND THE WINNER IS

Palit Radeon HD 4870 SONIC 1 GB



If you need a really fast card and you have anywhere near Rs 20,000 to spend on the same, the HD 4870 SONIC 1 GB should be at the top of your shopping list. Its as simple as that; and there is nothing more that you really have to consider. A card whose performance is at par, (for the most part), with the fastest card on the planet; at a price that is 40 per cent lower, makes buying this virtually a no-brainer.

Mid-Range

REIGNING CHAMPION

ZOTAC 9800 GTX AMP! Edition

This card is a gem. ZOTAC took a 9800 GTX GPU and overclocked it to an insane 756 MHz, up from the default speed of 675 MHz. At a price of Rs 10,555 this card is a superb mid-range piece of gaming equipment. It'll run most games at high resolutions and not pant in the process. It



also received our *Editors Pick* award and was the fastest mid-range graphics card in our test. On a budget of Rs 10,000 or so, do not even bother to look elsewhere.

CHALLENGER(S)

None

AND THE WINNER IS

ZOTAC 9800 GTX AMP! Edition

Nobody was able to challenge this card for a shot at our Zero 1 Award. We're awarding ZOTAC with this award, and we await even more superb products from this relative newcomer to our markets.

Entry-Level

REIGNING CHAMPION

EVGA 9600 GT

The entry level category is always fiercely competitive as all vendors look to offer best bang-for-buck. This card stood out for a number of reasons. It was a fraction slower than the fastest card in the category but was significantly cheaper. This card also featured a single slot cooling solution, very suitable for powerful HTPCs or a computer where space is restricted, or in case you need a PCI slot vacant for a sound card. The bundle was sparse, but in terms of performance and price EVGA's 9600 GT is unbeatable.

CHALLENGER(S)

None

AND THE WINNER IS

EVGA 9600 GT

A sweet card, for a sweet price of Rs 8,750; you may actually be able to get this card for a lot less, especially since NVIDIA has announced price drops recently. Although the price cuts haven't reflected in the Indian markets yet, it should have by the time you read this. If you want an introduction to gaming and this is your first PC, this card is just the thing to get.

